

Origin and aspect of the converb in Classical Armenian

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Towards a diachronic typology of converbs

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Guiding Questions

1. How and why does Classical Armenian develop a cvb category?
2. How does the CArm. cvb operate synchronically?
3. What sets the cvb category apart from other uses of the form?
4. How and why does it develop diachronically?

Outline

Background

Adjectival, periphrastic, and converbial uses

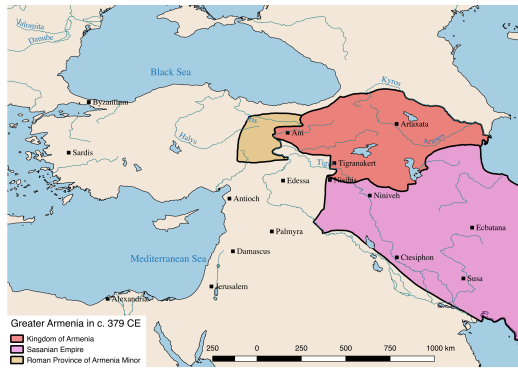
Synchronic use of the Converb

Rise and Fall of the Converb

Final thoughts

Brief background: Armenian

- ▶ Indo-European language, separate branch (CLACKSON 1994; HÜBSCHMANN 1875; MARTIROSYAN 2013)
- ▶ spoken in Armenian Highlands and surrounding area (modern Armenia, Iran, Turkey, Georgia, Azerbaijan)
- ▶ Classical form (5th–9th c.) heavily influenced by Iranian (BOLOGNESI 1960; SCHMITT 1983; MEYER in press)
- ▶ first attested in 5th c. (inscription), 9th c. (manuscript)
- ▶ on its history, cf. GARSOÏAN (1997*a,b,c*)



Verbal adjectives in *-eal*

- ▶ all CArm. verbs (except *em* ‘to be’ and a few defective ones) can form a verbal adjective in *-eal*
- ▶ traditionally called past participle
- ▶ formed on aorist stem or verbal root (for complications, cf. MEYER 2014)
- ▶ almost exclusively intransitive, passive when used as adjectives (v. few exceptions)
- ▶ perfective verbal aspect
- ▶ regularly, but rarely inflected as an o-stem
- ▶ a few frequent forms have been lexicalised
- ▶ Examples:
 - ▶ *sirem* ‘to love’ > *sireal* ‘(be)loved’
 - ▶ *asem* ‘to say’ > *asac’eal* ‘said’
 - ▶ *arāk’em* ‘to send’ > *arāk’eal* ‘sent’ → ‘apostle; emissary’

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Use case I: adnominal modifier

- (1) *ard dimeac' gal surb=n Grigorios zi k'andesc'ē ew z=ayn*
 PTC rush.3SG.AOR go.INF holy=DET PN COMP destroy.3SG.AOR.SBJV also OBJ=DEM
ews zi takawin isk tgēt mardik xaṛnakut'ean zohēin y=ays
 further COMP more PTC ignorant mankind confusion.GEN.SG sacrifice.3PL.PST to=DEM
bagins mnac'eals
 altar.LOC.PL remain.PTCP.LOC.PL

‘Then St. Grigor set out so that he might destroy this one, too, since ignorant men still sacrificed to Chaos at these **left over** altars.’ (Ag. §809)

- (2) *sałmosk' ēin noc'a mrmnĵunk' ergoc' ew ant'erc'uack' surb*
 psalm.NOM.PL be.3PL.PST 3PL.GEN whisper.NOM.PL song.GEN.PL and lesson.NOM.PL holy
groc' katareal uraxut'iwnk'
 scripture.GEN.PL **complete.PTCP** happiness.NOM.PL

‘Their whispers of songs were psalms, and the lessons in holy scripture their **supreme** happiness.’ (El. p. 125)

Use case I: adnominal modifier

- ▶ in a corpus study of 5th-c. historiographical texts (MEYER 2017), this usage accounts for c. 15% (1042 tokens)
- ▶ only 4 instances of transitively used participles occur, all in one author
- ▶ this distribution confirms the inherently intransitive, passive nature of the historical *-eal* form
- ▶ this is in keeping with comparative data and the historical morphosemantics of this and related forms (MEYER 2014, 2017:39–81)

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Use case II: periphrastic perfect

- ▶ the CArm. periphrastic perfect consists of the *-eal* participle and an (initially optional) copulative verb (*em* ‘to be’; *linim* ‘to become’; *kam* ‘to remain’)
- ▶ in the 5th c., the construction follows tripartite alignment (synthetic tenses: NOM-ACC):
 - ▶ subject: NOM
 - ▶ agent: GEN
 - ▶ direct object: ACC
- ▶ intransitive verbs exhibit subject-agreement in number, person
- ▶ transitive verbs have Ø-agreement, using a fossilised 3SG form (if used)
- ▶ present perfect / resultative meaning (cf. LYONNET 1933; OUZOUNIAN 2001; SEMĚNOVA 2016)
- ▶ more on the diachrony of this construction later

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

Intransitive verbs (S=NOM)

- (3) *ew ert'eal i kolmans Arami i k'alak's erkus Asorwoc'*
 CONJ arrive.PTCP to side.ACC.PL PN.GEN.SG in city.ACC.PL two Assyrian.GEN.PL
 '... and he arrived in the region of Aram, in two cities of the Assyrians ...' (Kor. VII.1)
- (4) *ew orpēs etun zroyc'ork' and nma ekeal ēin*
 and as give.3PL.AOR news REL.NOM.PL with 3SG.DAT come.PTCP be.3PL.PST
 'And as those, who had come with him, reported ...' (P'B IV.5)
- (5) *ayl duk' or ayžm y=erec'unc' ašxarhac' ekeal=d ēk'*
 but 2PL.NOM REL.NOM now from=three.ABL country.ABL.PL come.PTCP=DET be.2PL.PRS
tanuteark' ew sepuhk'
 magnate.NOM.PL and noble.NOM.PL
 'But you magnates and nobles, who have now come from three countries, ...' (LP' (2)§27)

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

Transitive verbs (A=GEN, O=ACC)

- (6) *ew gitem t'ē lueal ē z=xorhurds mer Parskac'*
 and know.1SG.PRS COMP hear.PTCP be.3SG.PRS OBJ=plan.ACC.PL 1PL.POSS Persian.GEN.PL
kapen z=na ew vštac'uc'anen
 bind.3PL.PRS OBJ=3SG.ACC and torment.3PL.PRS
 'I know that [if] the Persians have heard our plans, they [will] imprison and torment him.'
 (LP' (3)§66)
- (7) *ew lueal ews ē im [t'ē i Parsiks xōsi]*
 and hear.PTCP further be.3SG.PRS 1SG.GEN [COMP to Persian.ACC.PL say.3SG]
 'And I have also heard that he is talking to the Persians.' (P'B V.4)

Use case II: periphrastic perfect

- ▶ in the same 5th-c. study, this usage accounts for c. 30% (1989 tokens)
- ▶ other, more marginal patterns than those illustrated above exist, too (different participant marking)
- ▶ the data suggests:
 - ▶ slow decline of tripartite alignment, rise of NOM-ACC pattern
 - ▶ use of copula rising (rare in older, very common in younger texts) → internal development

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Use case III: converb

- ▶ ancient Indo-European languages are not commonly said to have a distinct CVB category (depending on definition)
- ▶ exception: Vedic Sanskrit (according to TIKKANEN 1987)?
- ▶ the CArm. *-eal* forms fulfil all key criteria (following one possible interpretation), however:
 - ▶ e.g. ‘nonfinite verb form whose main function is to mark adverbial subordination’ (HASPELMATH 1995:3)
 - ▶ type: free/varying-subject converb (may but need not share matrix verb subject; NEDJALKOV cf. 1995:110–11)
 - ▶ semantics: contextual converb (NEDJALKOV 1995:108–9, KÖNIG 1995:59–64)
 - ▶ next to adverbial use, clause-chaining and cases of para-hypotaxis (in Ross’ terms) can also be found
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Converb: intransitive

Shared subject

- (8) *isk na hawaneal vaṭvaṭaki barbareal asēr*

PTC 3SG.NOM believe.CVB suddenly speak.CVB say.3SG.PST

‘And having been convinced, he suddenly spoke and said ...’ (Ag. §794)

Different subject

- (9) *ew ankeal zawrawork‘=n i sur t‘šnameac‘=n meṛaw k‘aǰ‘=n*

and fall.CVB soldier.NOM.PL=DET into sword enemy.GEN.PL=DET die.3SG.AOR valiant=DET

Mamikonean Vasak

PN

PN

‘And as the soldiers engaged the enemies in battle (lit. fell on the swords of the enemies), the valiant Vasak Mamikonean died.’ (ŁP‘ §69)

Converb: transitive

Shared subject

- (10) *ew amenayn əst asac'eloy patuirani=n arareal handerjeal*
 and *all* according-to say.PTCP.GEN.SG command.GEN.SG=DET *make.CVB prepare.CVB*
kazmeal patrastec'in
decorate.CVB prepare.3PL.AOR

‘And they *made, prepared, decorated*, and arranged *everything* according to the command given.’ (Ag. §760)

Different subject

- (11) *z=ors and žamanaks žamanaks iwrov isk anjamb=n*
OBJ=REL.ACC.PL with time.ACC.PL time.ACC.PL 3POSS.INS.SG PTC self.INS.SG=DET
awrinak c'uc'eal, areal z=omans y=ašakertac'=n [...]
example.ACC.SG show.CVB take.CVB OBJ=INDF.ACC.PL from=student.GEN.PL=DET
z=ařawreak=n xotabut čašakawk'=n včarēin
OBJ=daily=DET vegetarian subsistence.INS.SG=DET settle.3PL.PST

‘These things he *demonstrated* from time to time, with himself as an example, *taking some* of his students ... [they] settled with their daily, vegetarian diet.’ (Kor. XXII.1)

Converbs: issues

Subject/Agent licensing

- ▶ converbs broadly follow the tripartite alignment pattern of the periphrastic perfect
- but when occurring with a matrix verb in a synthetic tense, either may determine agent case (NOM or GEN)
- ▶ the same applies when a converb is co-ordinated with matrix clauses (~ morphologically tripartite; also cf. para-hypotaxis)

(12) *bazum mardik haneal z=jukn ōgtēin i nmanē*
many mankind.NOM.SG pull-out.CVB OBJ=fish.ACC.SG profit.3PL.PST from 3SG.ABL
'Many men, having caught the fish, profited from it.' (P'B V.27)

(13) *uleworac'='n tueal patasxani asac'in*
traveller.GEN.PL=DET give.CVB answer.ACC.SG say.3PL.AOR
'The travellers gave an answer and said: ...' (P'B V.43)

Converbs: issues

Differentiating converbs and perfects without copula

- ▶ in many respects, the converbial and perfective use of the participle are similar
- ▶ the occurrence of the *-eal* form as a main verb without copula makes it difficult to differentiate the two usages
- ▶ in the corpus mentioned, the two were differentiated on the basis of co-/subordination:
 - ▶ converbs and their arguments are not separated from the matrix clause verb by sub- or co-ordinating conjunctions
 - ▶ AUX-less perfects may be so separated

but note the different aspects: perfective CVB vs resultative PF

- ▶ How can these parallels between perfect and converb be explained?

Example: Para-hypotaxis

- (14) *zc'ayg ew zc'erek nsteal vardapetac' ew əst nmanut'ean ampoc'=n ibrew*
 by-night and by-day **sit.PTCP teacher.GEN.PL and** in likeness.DAT.SG cloud.GEN.SG like
z=yordahetel inč' anjrewac' sastkut'iwn z=vardapetut'iwn=n i veray
 OBJ=overflowing INDF rain.GEN.PL intensity.ACC.SG OBJ=teaching.ACC.SG=DET on-top
hosēin
 pour.3PL.PST

'Day and night, **teachers sat** [there] **and** poured over [them] the abundance [that is] their teaching like some torrential rain from the clouds' (P'B III.13)

Background: perfect

- ▶ the origin of the tripartite perfect is debated (MEILLET 1936; BENVENISTE 1952; STEMPEL 1983; WEITENBERG 1986, etc.)
- ▶ one recent approach ascribes its origin to language contact with Parthian (MEYER 2017)
- ▶ the Parthian split-ergative system was replicated and adapted to Armenian (the system shows sufficient remnants of ergative alignment; for the concept of pattern replication: MATRAS AND SAKEL 2007)
- ▶ key elements of the model, the Parthian past tense: adjectival form of the verb, non-nominative agent, lack of copulative verb in 3SG (elsewhere OBJ-agreement)

- (15) *kw* *ʿym*, *cy=m* *ʿc* *tw* *wxʹšt*, *ʿw mn* *wʿcʹh*
COMP DEM REL=1SG.OBL from 2SG request.PTCP to 1SG.OBL say.2SG.SBJV
‘That which I requested from you, may you tell me [it]!’ (MKG 1610–11)

In favour of a contact explanation

- ▶ transitive development of the converb and perfect (as found in Parthian), which presents serious explicatory problems for other approaches
- ▶ other replicated syntagmata in Classical Armenian (MEYER 2013, 2017:219–254)
- ▶ similar instances of pattern replications in other languages of the Iranian periphery (MEYER 2019)
- ▶ historical evidence (extended contact, bilingualism, intermarriage, etc.)
- ▶ explanatory maxim: rule out internal developments before belabouring contact explanations (POPLACK AND LEVEY 2010)

Rise of the Converb

- ▶ the similarities between perfect and converb suggest that one arose from the other
- ▶ the diachronic trend of the copulative perfect shows that it was rare in the earlier 5th-c. texts (<10%), but a firm standard in later texts (>75%; nascent obligatorification)
- ▶ at the (pre-literary) time of replication, it appears that the initial pattern replicated on the model of Parthian was grammaticalised as follows:
 - ▶ pivot matching: participle
 - ▶ polysemy / polyfunctionality copying: extension of ADJ use of PTCP to verbal function (incl. transitivity)
- and reanalysis: adnominal → adverbial
 - ▶ adaptation: tripartite alignment, no copula
- ▶ the suggestion that the originally new pattern was restricted to converbial use is based on the incidence of this use and the absence of other finite verbal forms lacking agreement
- ▶ a later, separate, internal process led to the rise of the copula, the aspectual shift to present perfect / resultative, and the eventual ousting of the converb in favour of the perfect

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Fall of the Converb

- ▶ while stable in literary Classical Armenian, the converbial use was ousted in Middle Armenian (from 9th c.)

[...] das kilikisch-mittelarmenische Partizip auf -ⁱel ist rein verbaler Natur und erscheint [...] nur mehr einzig und ausschließlich als Bildungsfaktor von Tempora periphrastica in Verbindung mit dem Verbum substantivum (KARST 1901:355)

- ▶ the transition to NOM-ACC alignment and a copulative form is readily explained by system pressure / cross-system harmony (cf. HAIG 2008:193)
- ▶ it is unclear whether the loss of the converb was immediately connected to this process
- ▶ the function of the participle has not changed in Modern Eastern Armenian, where it is still only used for the formation of the perfect (DUM-TRAGUT 2009:213-4)

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Final thoughts

- ▶ converbs are a transient category in Classical Armenian
 - ▶ likely the result of language contact with Parthian
 - ▶ arising from a grammaticalisation process that, later, would produce a periphrastic perfect
 - ▶ their marginalisation and loss coincides with the obligatorification of the copular perfect
- but it remains unclear whether there is a causal relationship
- ▶ no comparable uses or forms exist in later varieties of the language
-
- ▶ a further, more detailed investigation into potential differences between perfective and converbial use of the *-eal* participle remains a desideratum

Thank you for your attention!

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